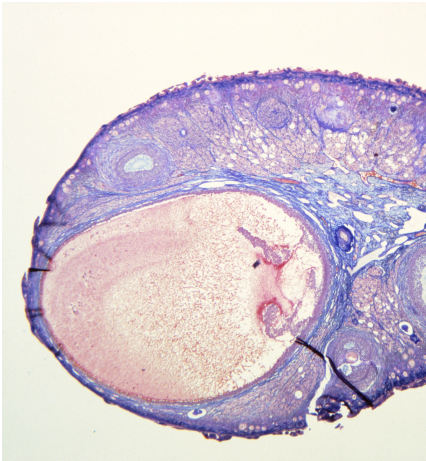




THIS IS **DAY 12 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
268 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

This mature ovarian follicle contains a fluid-filled cavity (pale pink) known as the follicular antrum. At this stage, just prior to ovulation, one follicle has become much larger than the others, and it is this follicle that will rupture to release an egg.

“As your hormone level rises around this stage of your cycle, so might your libido—it seems nature takes care of everything!”

Estrogen levels are rising and reach their peak today, based on a 28-day menstrual cycle. The rise in estrogen from the follicles is what stimulates the release of the [LH hormone](#), which surges about 24 hours before ovulation. [FSH](#) from the pituitary gland starts rising later this week. Progesterone levels are low. There's no call for this hormone until the uterus lining needs to thicken. In fact, high levels would make the cervix hostile to sperm, so they would have trouble getting through to the uterus and the fallopian tubes to fertilize the egg.

Women also produce testosterone, which reaches a peak around ovulation. This male hormone is responsible for libido in both sexes so both you and your partner may be in the mood for making babies.

Try to stay as relaxed as you can, because being stressed can affect your ability to conceive. One reason might be that it reduces the ovary's response to the luteinizing hormone surge at midcycle. There is also a link between stress and the failure of fertility treatments.